

Planning Context and Proposed Ohio River South Shore Trail (ORSST) Alignment

the town is \$19,472 and 5.1 percent of the population live below the poverty line, below Pennsylvania’s rate of 12.1 percent. The estimated population in 2006 was 506, representing a 22 percent drop from the 1990 population of 647.

Crescent Township is also primarily a suburban township with a total area of 2.3 square miles. The Township has approximately 1.4 miles of Ohio River frontage, all within Section 400 of the ORSST study area.

Crescent Township consists of approximately 2,314 people and 886 households. The racial makeup of the area is 97.2 percent White, 1.3 percent African American, 0.7 percent Hispanic, 0.3 percent Native American, and 0.9 percent Asian. The per capital income of the town is \$16,400 and 9.6 percent live below the poverty line, below Pennsylvania’s rate of 12.1 percent.

History and Cultural Resources

Hopewell Township was once a much larger municipality, the center of original development activity was in the upper elevation areas of what is today Broadhead Road. All of what constitutes Aliquippa today was carved out of Hopewell Township in 1893. The portions of the Township that are included in the ORSST study area are industrial areas located between the City of Aliquippa and South Heights Borough, which was once part of Hopewell Township as well. It is believed that the name of the Township is derived from a Presbyterian church organized around 1790 or 1800.

South Heights was first known as Ethel’s Landing, a docking point on the Ohio River. The name of the town was changed to Shannopin reputedly after an Indian warrior. In the 1880’s, oil fields were discovered and that brought an influx of people to the village. The Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad came to the area in 1872 and originally ran where Jordan Street/PA Route 51 exists today. In the early 1900s a brick factory and the Keystone Torpeda and Power Company were located there. In 1910, the 150 inhabitants of the town voted to incorporate as a Borough and change the name of the town to South Heights.

Crescent Township’s history on the Ohio River dates back to 1784-1785, when warrants were recorded for “Fortune”, Limerick” and “Strabane” riverfront properties. An old English law required that any sold property must be named. Each property consisted of 400 acres. The area was settled by Revolutionary War soldiers who bought their land from the Commonwealth of Pennsylvania.

A son of German emigrants, Peter Shouse came here with his family in 1822 after he had built boats in Monongahela and Pittsburgh, and after he had served in Ohio during the War of 1812. Intending to operate his own boatyard, he purchased “Limerick Landing”, which was the location of a pool in the Ohio River approximately 20 feet deep. This spot provided an exceptional location for launching new boats. The boatyard brought many workers who cut timber from the thick virgin forests that covered nearby hillsides.

Limerick Landing and the boatyard were incorporated into Shousetown when that new community was established by Peter Shouse, and the entire area was part of Moon Township, one of the first seven townships designated when Allegheny County was formed in 1788. Muddy roads made getting to the polls in Moon Township difficult, so a petition was prepared, asking that the Quarter Session Court in Allegheny County establish a separate Township. This was granted in 1855, and the new municipality was named “Crescent” because it was a small part of Moon.

The steamboat hulls built and launched at Shousetown by Peter Shouse and later boatyard owners were towed up the shallow Ohio River to Pittsburgh for rigging and furnishing before going into service. Many became famous, such as the “Buckeye State”, which broke the speed record going from Cincinnati to Pittsburgh in 43 hours in 1850 - - a record that still stands.

The first home ports of these boats varied - ten went to New Orleans: the “Freeman Rawden” went to New York City for service between there and Washington D.C. The “Chamois” went to Apalachicola, FL, nine went to St. Louis, Mo. and 76 were originally assigned to Pittsburgh. Some saw action in the Civil War after conversion to gun boats by the Federal government. A total of 102 boats were launched from Shousetown - the grand finale was the 1727 ton “Great Republic”, the biggest ship built there, constructed shortly before the boatyard was closed.

Railroad service on the northeast side of the Ohio River tied Pittsburgh to Sewickleyville (Leetsdale) and points west in 1856. On the southwest side of the river, train service from Pittsburgh to Beaver Falls started in 1879. A railroad station, a station agent and railroad siding eventually were added at Crescent. Commuting trains ran from Beaver Falls to Pittsburgh. Since the school in Crescent went only to eighth grade, high school students had their choice of attending Ambridge, Aliquippa or Coraopolis high schools. Transportation was at their own expense, with many using a train to Coraopolis or taking a commercial bus to Ambridge or Aliquippa. Going to Coraopolis on the train was a common Saturday occurrence - to shop, dine or attend a movie.

Before the train came through Shousetown, a need to transport passengers, mail and freight across the river caused the establishment in 1845 of ferry service connecting the community to Sewickleyville from Ferry Street. A bridge was built in Sewickley in 1911 and when one was built in Ambridge in 1929, the ferry service ended.

Another thriving business, established in 1894, was a brickyard at Briggston on the main line of the Pittsburgh and Lake Erie Railroad, situated about 100 feet back from the Ohio River, near the current location of Shouse Park. Owned by Pittsburgh Brick Company, the business employed 22 men and boys and produced about 30,000 bricks daily, using clay and shale found at the site.

Brigadier General Lachlan McIntosh, who was named Commander of the Western Department in 1778, supervised the construction of a military supply road from Fort Pitt in Pittsburgh to Fort McIntosh in what is today

Section 400 – Hopewell Township - South Heights Borough - Crescent Township

Community Character and Demographic Overview

Hopewell Township is primarily a suburban township with a total area of 17 square miles. The Township has .24 miles of Ohio River frontage in Section 400. This area is entirely industrial and has active industrial uses operating there today.

Over the past ten years, the population of Hopewell Township has declined slightly from 13,274 in 1990 to an estimated 12,598 in 2006. The number of households has increased as a result of its growing suburbanization. The racial makeup of the area is 91.8 percent White, 7.4 percent African American, 0.04 percent Hispanic, 0.01 percent Native American, and 0.32 percent Asian. The per capital income of the town is \$20,802 and 6 percent of the population live below the poverty line.

South Heights Borough is a small municipality with a total area of 0.4 square miles. The Borough has approximately 0.7 miles of Ohio River frontage all of which is located within Section 400 of the ORSST study area.

South Heights Borough consists of approximately 542 people and 239 households based on the 2000 census. The racial makeup of the area is 98.5 percent White, 0.74 percent African American, 0.3 percent Hispanic, 0.0 percent Native American, and 0.18 percent Asian. The per capital income of

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Beaver County, along a ridge on the south side of the Ohio River. Colonel Daniel Brodhead succeeded to the command of Fort McIntosh in 1779, and the road was named after him. Brodhead Road serves as a boundary of Crescent Township. Along with the Ohio River and the railroad, it brought settlers to the area as well as pioneers passing through on their way to new lives in the West.

The town formerly called “Wireton” was originally named “Anderson Road” and was located along the south side of the Ohio River, adjacent to the Beaver County line. Its major industry was the Phillips Power Station of Duquesne Light.

There are no sites listed on the National Register of Historic Places within Section 400. As described above, the area historically had many small industrial businesses. The identified historic resources within the study area include:

- *The Pennsylvania Historical Museum Commission Marker for the Shouse Boat Yard and its founder, Peter Shouse, who built the “Kentuckian,” its first steamboat, in 1829. Sold in 1837 to E. & N. Porter. By 1866 over 80 steamboats had been launched. The last was the 1727-ton “Great Republic,” famed on the Mississippi River for its size and elegance; and*
- *Allegheny County Marker for the “Place of Beginning” where the survey of Allegheny Commence from Washington County and Westmoreland County on September 24, 1788. (This marker is located at the terminus of Ferry Street at the Ohio River).*

Land Use, Parks and Recreation Resources and River Access

The land uses within Section 400 are very mixed. The area in Hopewell Township is mostly vacant or not developable industrial lands. South Heights Borough is mostly a residential “village” with some minor commercial uses. The major industrial land use in the South Heights Borough is mostly located in Crescent Township and extends into the South Heights Borough. That use is the former Frank R. Phillips Coal-Fired Power Station, which is no longer in operation and is being fully decommissioned and moth-balled. The administration building from the Power Station is located in South Heights Borough and is being reused for commercial uses. The future of the remainder of the land is not known.

Beyond the Power Station, most of the Crescent Township riverfront consists of a mix of heavy industrial uses, including small steel making, aggregate processing and scrap metal related business. The area from Main Street to Ferry Street is residential, including several properties along the riverfront. McGovern Boulevard/PA Route 51 through Crescent Township has small pockets of retail businesses mixed in with stretches of residential dwellings. It is important to note that many of the residential dwellings that front on McGovern Boulevard do not have off-street parking, so on-street parking in the location is critical.

South Heights Borough has one public park and recreation facility located within or close to the proposed trail route within the ORSST study area:

- *South Heights Municipal Park.*

The Crescent Township Fire Department also owns a lawn area located next to the South Heights Borough Park that the Borough has expressed a desire to merge into their park to form a larger public space at the core of the community.

Crescent Township has two public parks located within the ORSST study area:

- *Shouse Park, which is located on a bluff overlooking the Ohio River; and*
- *Riverview Park.*

Currently there is no direct public river access in Section 400. Although Shouse Park is located on the Ohio River, its elevation is well above the height of the river and there is no access from the park down to the river’s edge. Most of the riverfront is lined with active industrial parcels, several of which have active marine transfer operations making public river access challenging.

Environmental Context and Infrastructure

River’s Edge and Habitat: Based on field observation, there are areas of erosion disturbance along the river’s edge as well as significant areas of invasive exotic vegetation with poor soil stabilization characteristics. The riverfront area in South Heights Borough has significant vegetated areas from the river’s edge to the CSX Railroad right-of-way. This area has not been disturbed recently, especially since the Power Station stopped rail siding service. The riverfront areas around Iron City Steel and West Penn Aggregates, in Crescent Township, are highly disturbed and there is active barge service to West Penn Aggregates.

Streams and Stormwater: It was very difficult to determine the status of the stream outfalls in the Hopewell Township and South Heights Borough area. One stream course outfall was indentified on the Crescent Authority Property located adjacent to the South Heights Borough Park. This area was filled with debris as a result of dumping and was heavily vegetated with invasive plant species. This stream flows through a culvert underneath the CSX Railroad and discharges close to the Ohio River’s edge.

There is a stream course that has an outfall in the area between Porter and Maple Streets. This area is a deep cut adjacent to a residential neighborhood and is also an area that is heavily wooded and could become a small community park. Debris and dumping were observed as well as severe erosion on the site. The stream also enters a culvert underneath the CSX Railroad before discharging into the Ohio River.

Spring Run and Flaugherty Run are both mostly day-lighted streams for most of their courses. The two streams converge in Riverview Park. At this point Flaugherty Run travels underneath the CSX Railroad and then meanders through the Glenwillard Boat Club to the Ohio River. The portion of the stream from the railroad to the river is privately owned and the route appears to have been significantly altered as a result of the many years of various development activities in this area.

As with many older urban communities, much of the municipal sewage system consist of combined sewer outfalls (CSOs). Opportunities to reduce stormwater flowing directly into the sewer system through improved site-specific infiltration projects that help to alleviate CSO impacts on the environment should be integrated into trail design projects wherever possible.

Transportation Infrastructure

Jordan Road/McGovern Boulevard/PA Route 51 is the main east/west roadway that parallels the Ohio River and the CSX Railroad right-of-way from the City of Pittsburgh through Crescent Township, Hopewell Township and South Heights Borough to Monaca, across the Monaca Rochester Bridge and to the west. PA Route 51 is designated by PennDOT as the Pennsylvania Bicycle Route A through the entire ORSST Study Area, including through Section 400. PA Route 51 in Section 400 has an average daily traffic (ADT) volume of approximately 7,800 in South Heights Borough and 7,200 in Crescent Township. Interestingly, these volumes are lower than both the downtown center of Monaca where the ADT is 10,000 and Coraopolis, on 5th Avenue, where the ADT is 9,000, yet traffic safety and speeding appears to be more of an issue on the Crescent Township portion of PA Route 51.

The community in this portion of the ORSST study area expressed concerns over the safety of the current transportation system. Specific concerns were raised regarding the physical attributes of the roadways and intersections as well as the overall maintenance of the network. One key maintenance concern that was especially emphasized was the need to clean the roadway shoulders to remove cinders and debris, especially since PA Route 51 is designated as a bike route. Since this roadway passes through what could be described as a “village-like” setting an engineering approach that enhances the community character and creates a safer setting for pedestrians and bicyclists could be employed. In this area streetscaping with traffic calming measures, improved sidewalks, enhanced ladder-style crosswalks, street trees and architectural lighting could be employed to create a stronger sense of a place as well as signaling to motorists that it is a setting that requires that they travel slowly and not speed. Improved coordination between the local municipalities, Allegheny County and PennDOT will be important in ensuring that the infrastructure is properly maintained for local residents and trail users.

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PA Route 51 in South Heights Borough

McGovern Boulevard/PA Route 51, as it turns to the south near the intersection of Spring Run Road, changes character again. At this point the roadway becomes more suburban in character with a mix of larger lot residential dwellings and small scale commercial uses. In this area there are very narrow shoulders ranging from 1' to 3' in width. There are also numerous driveway curb cuts and intermittent sidewalks. PA Route 51 diverges from McGovern Boulevard at the intersection of Stoops Ferry Road where it turns to the east at this intersection. PA Route 51 has an average daily traffic volume of approximately 11,000 at this intersection.

Economic Development

None of the municipalities in this section have specified economic development strategies or plans which might impact the planning, design or future economic impact of the ORSST route. Crescent Township has expressed a desire to see the Power Station demolished and the site be redeveloped in some manner. It would appear that the site's PA Route 51 frontage alone would allow for a new walk-able mixed-use development with ground floor "main street" type retail and multi-family residential behind and above the retail. The site could serve as a location to stimulate new public and private investment in the area as well as a way to expand the municipal tax base. The portion of the site that is located between the CSX Railroad and the Ohio River should be dedicated for a public riverfront park including a riverfront trail and promenade, which would be accessible to all residents as well as provide added economic benefit to the adjacent mixed-use infill development project. In order for such a project to advance, Crescent Township, South Heights Borough and Allegheny

County would need to work in partnership with the current owners of the Power Station site as well as with state and federal agencies to develop a feasible redevelopment strategy.

Proposed ORSST Route and Alternatives

Seven potential routing alternatives, including the proposed ORSST route were identified for Section 400. Due to the complex parcels arrangement, land use context and existing characteristics of PA Route 51, this section has several potentially viable options; however, most of these options have complexities that need to be studied in more detail to determine their ultimate viability.

Proposed ORSST Route Description through Section 400

The proposed ORSST route through Section 400 will extend from a 10' wide sidepath located along a reconstructed Woodlawn Road in the City of Aliquippa from Section 300, to North Street in South Heights Borough. At the location where North Street travels underneath the CSX Railroad right-of-way, via a curved roadway and underpass, the trail would cross North Street to the river side of the roadway. From this point the trail would travel through a series of privately owned parcels via a new 10' wide multi-use path to the area of the existing Power Plant Road Bridge. It is believed that the trail could be located on a former rail siding roadbed that once served the Power Station in this location. From this point it would extend to Section 500, via right-of-way acquired from CSX on the Ohio River side of the existing railroad tracks.

Route Characteristics and Issues

At the bridge on Power Plant Road, the trail would move to the edge of the CSX Railroad's right-of-way, on the right-of-way would need to be acquired from the railroad. The trail would then travel parallel to the railroad to McCutcheon Way, at the entrance to Shouse Park. In addition to negotiations with the CSX Railroad over the acquisition of the right-of-way, a detailed engineering study, along with metes and bounds survey will be required to determine if ample setback exists. The Federal Highway Administration recommends a setback range from the centerline of the closest rail line of 25' to 50' or more depending on site conditions. A physical separation will be required with a minimum of right-of-way fencing or other more substantial forms of a physical barrier and in some cases a vertical separation. Currently there is little to no right-of-way fencing along the railroad in this area.



CSX Right-of-Way and Undevelopable Land along Riverfront

Proposed Route Lengths

Total Length of Route through Hopewell Township (Section 400) 10' Wide Multi Use Path = .25 miles

Total Length of Route through South Heights Borough 10' wide Multi Use Path = .5 miles

Crescent Township On-Road Portion = .3 miles

Crescent Township 10' Wide Multi Use Path = .8 miles

Total Length of Route through Crescent Township (Section 400) = 1.4 miles

Identified ORSST Routing Alternatives in Section 400

Alternative 400A

Description: This route would be a signed on-road route through the North Street underpass to Cherry Alley. The on-road would travel along Cherry Alley past the South Heights Municipal Park. It would then travel through a Borough owned right-of-way located next to the auto repair facility located adjacent to Bradbury Drive. This would create a connection from Cherry Alley to Jordan Street/PA Route 51. From this point the trail would consist of a 10' wide sidepath along the north side PA Route 51 past the Borough Hall and the former Power Station administration building to Power Plant Road, where it could travel over the Power Plant Road Bridge to one of the other identified alternatives, or continue along PA Route 51.

Issues and Opportunities: The on-road portions of this alternative are simple to establish and should be considered as a feeder trail to connect the South Heights Municipal Park to the proposed ORSST route. The portion of the trail that would be created along PA Route 51 would require determining the width of PennDOT's right-of-way to determine if a 10' wide sidepath could be created within the existing right-of-way. If available right-of-way doesn't exist additional right-of-way or access easements would need to

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be obtained from each of the four property owners. The portion along PA Route 51 could also be signed as an on-road route. This segment of PA Route 51 is designated as Pennsylvania Bicycle Route A. Recent crosswalk improvements were made in this segment of PA Route 51. Trailblazer signing and additional safety improvements, such as traffic calming, could be considered as well as curb bump outs for key crossing locations and enhanced roadway striping and markings.

Alternative 400B

Description: This alternative focuses on locating the trail as close to the river as possible. It would consist of 10' wide multi-use path that would extend through Power Station property and five large industrial parcels to the western end of Main Street in Crescent Township.

Issues and Opportunities: This alternative considers the option of running the trail parallel to the CSX Railroad just outside of the railroad's right-of-way. All of the industrial parcels, with the exception of the Power Station have active industrial uses. Many of the operations have buildings located near the railroad right-of-way. A detailed engineering study of the property boundaries would need to be performed as well as the acquisition of rights-of-way or easement through each of the parcels would need to be negotiated to be able to construct this segment.

Alternative 400C

Description: This alternative consists of extending the 10' wide sidepath described in Alternative 400A along the frontage of the Power Station property. The trail would travel as a signed on-road route along PA Route 51 from Jeanette Street to McCutcheon Road. The trail would travel as a signed on-road route along McCutcheon Road across the CSX Railroad at-grade crossing to Dashields Lock Road and then via this roadway to the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers Parking Lot located in Section 500.

Issues and Opportunities: If the 10' wide sidepath for the portion of the trail along the Power Station frontage is not feasible, for reason as described in Alternative 400A, it could be signed as an on-road route. Trailblazer signing and additional safety improvements, such as traffic calming, could be considered as well as curb bump outs for key crossing locations and enhanced roadway striping and markings.

This segment of PA Route 51 from Jeanette Street to McCutcheon Road also serves as a major gateway through the Township with residential and commercial uses and should be considered for streetscape and safety improvements including traffic calming, curb bump-outs, crossing warning signals and architectural lighting and landscaping.

The portion of the trail along McCutcheon Way from PA Route 51 to Dashields Lock Road would also be an on-road route. This small segment consists of a relatively low-traffic roadway. The roadway, however, has significant horizontal and vertical constraints and poor site lines. The roadway has a horseshoe curve/switchback that rises from the low elevation of Riverview

Park to the significantly higher elevation of Shouse Park. Based on field observations it appears that a side path could be created along the outside of the curve with a switch-back boardwalk to address current constraints. More detailed engineering studies would be required to determine what design options are feasible.

The trail would travel as a signed on-road route along Dashields Lock Road from McCutcheon Way to the Crescent Township Line and U.S. Army Corps of Engineers Parking Lot.



CSX Right-of-Way at McCutcheon Way

Alternative 400D

Description: This alternative consists of an on-road route south of PA Route 51. The route would travel from PA Route 51 south on Bocktown Road to Prospect Street and back to PA Route 51.

Issues and Opportunities: This route was identified in a public meeting as a potential alternative for study. It was determined, based on field observations, that the route had several fatal flaws, including steep grades, narrow roadway widths and poor site lines and wasn't studied further.

Alternative 400E

Description: This alternative is linked to Alternative 500A and consists of the current Pennsylvania Bicycle Route A, which travels on PA Route 51/McGovern Boulevard to Stoops Ferry Road.

Issues and Opportunities: This segment of PA Route 51 links to the segment in Section 500 which has the highest traffic volumes within the ORSST study area. McGovern Road has an average traffic volume of 11,000. Stoops Ferry Road has an average daily traffic volume of approximately 14,000. Stoops Ferry Road also has a significant topographic change that would create a major barrier for recreational bicyclists to climb. Stoops Ferry Road

does have 10' wide average shoulders on each side. The bridge crossing of Flaugherty Run is also very narrow and its sidewalks are not ADA compliant and it is located at an intersection with "free" northbound right turns which increases the potential for safety conflicts for pedestrians and bicyclists.

Alternative 400F

Description: This alternative consists of a signed on-road route from PA Route 51, north along Jeannette Street to McKae Street, Division Street, Porter Street, Maple Street and returns to PA Route 51.

Issues and Opportunities: This route relies on several small neighborhood streets that are in poor condition and requires a significant amount of weaving through the neighborhood. The connection between Porter Street and Maple Street has major topographic changes and the ownership of a right-of-way connection along the CSX Railroad right-of-way is not known.

Alternative 400G

Description: This alternative routes the trail on-road via Main Street from PA Route 51, past Ferry Street, underneath the CSX Railroad to McCutcheon Road.

Issues and Opportunities: Main Street has low traffic volumes and is a neighborhood street and can easily serve as a share-the-road condition. Site lines through the CSX underpass are not optimal and safety improvements and signing would need to be studied in this area.

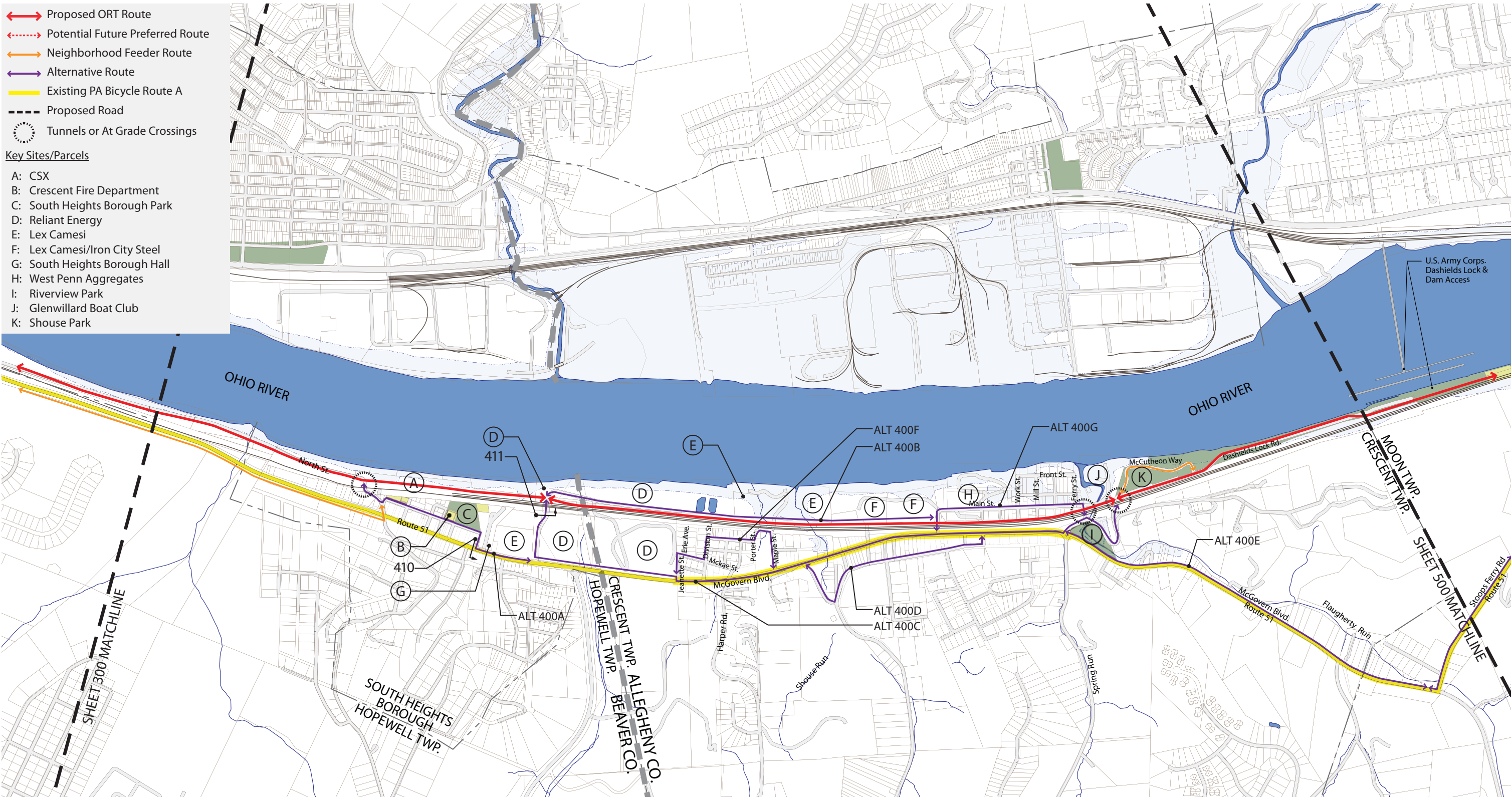
Hopewell Township - South Heights Borough - Cresnet Township - 400

LEGEND

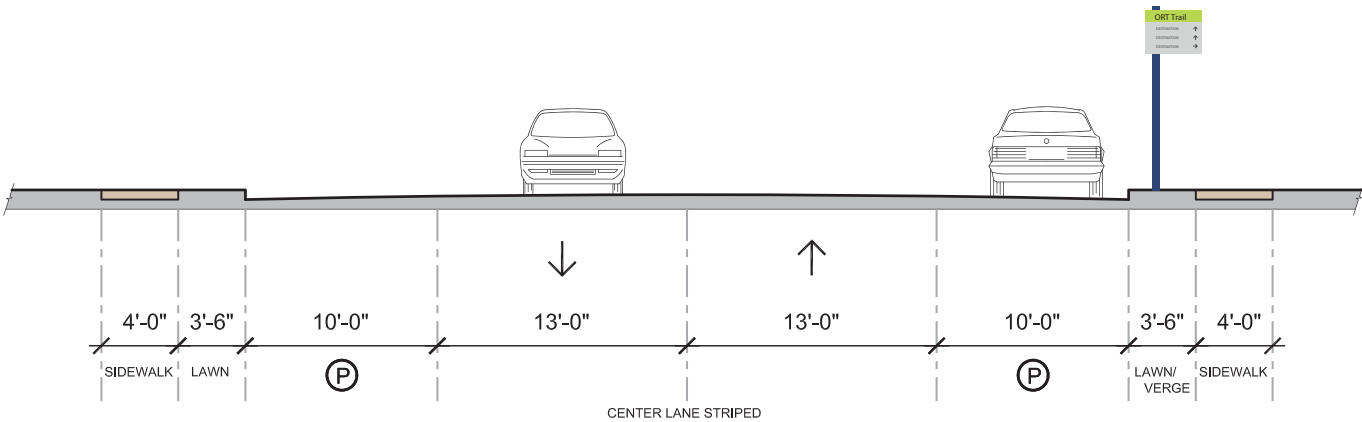
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- Potential Future Preferred Route
- Neighborhood Feeder Route
- Alternative Route
- Existing PA Bicycle Route A
- Proposed Road
- Tunnels or At Grade Crossings

Key Sites/Parcels

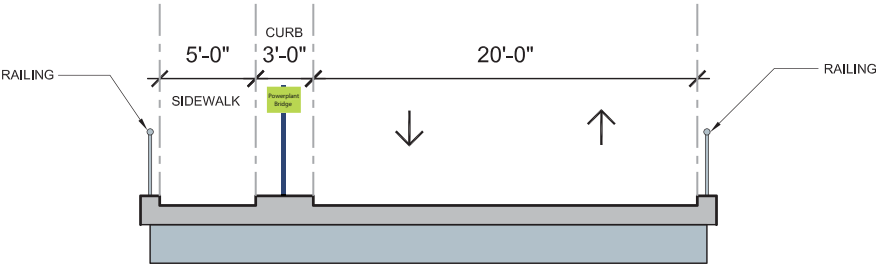
- A: CSX
- B: Crescent Fire Department
- C: South Heights Borough Park
- D: Reliant Energy
- E: Lex Camesi
- F: Lex Camesi/Iron City Steel
- G: South Heights Borough Hall
- H: West Penn Aggregates
- I: Riverview Park
- J: Glenwillard Boat Club
- K: Shouse Park



SCALE: Not to Scale NORTH



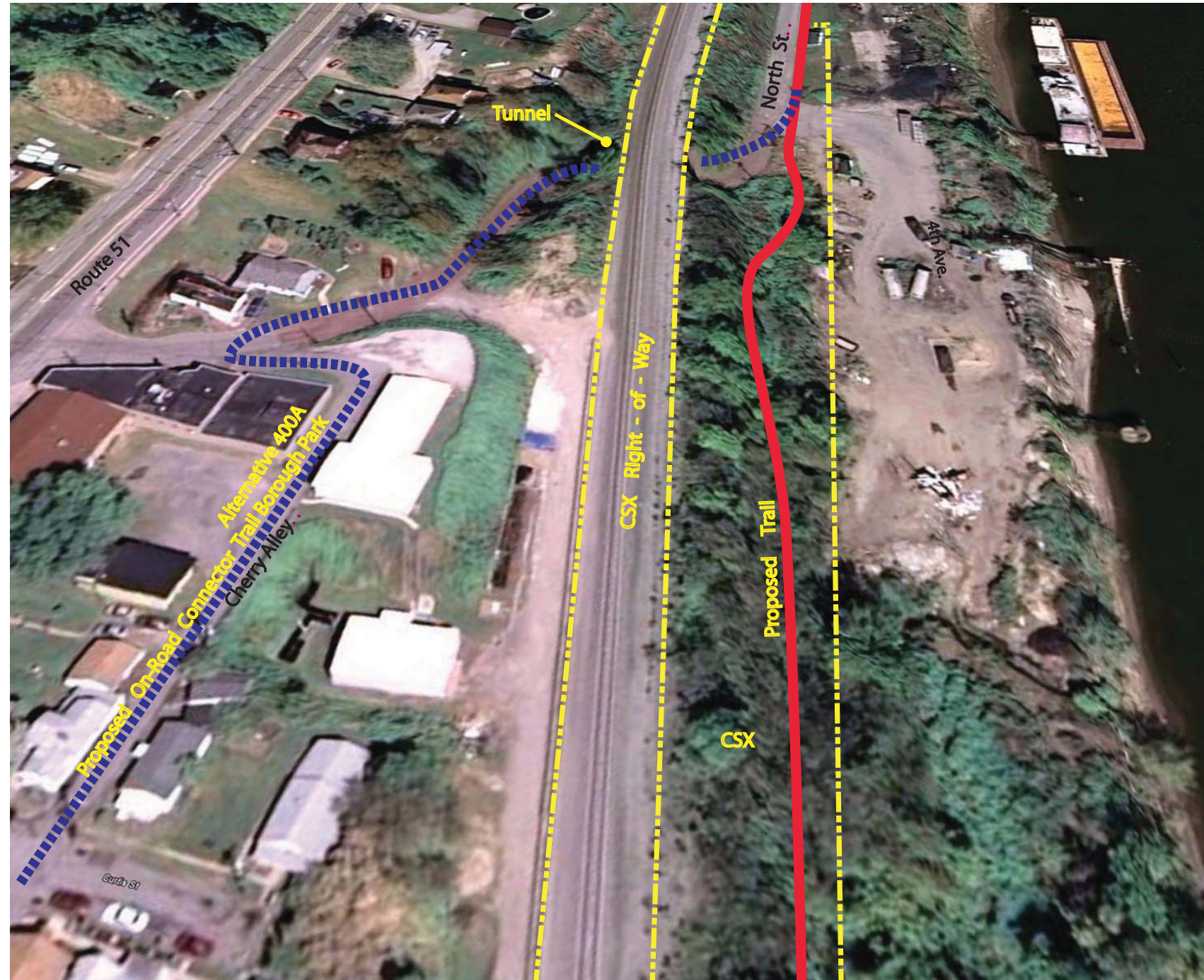
410 RT 51 AT SOUTH HEIGHTS BOROUGH HALL LOOKING EAST (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'



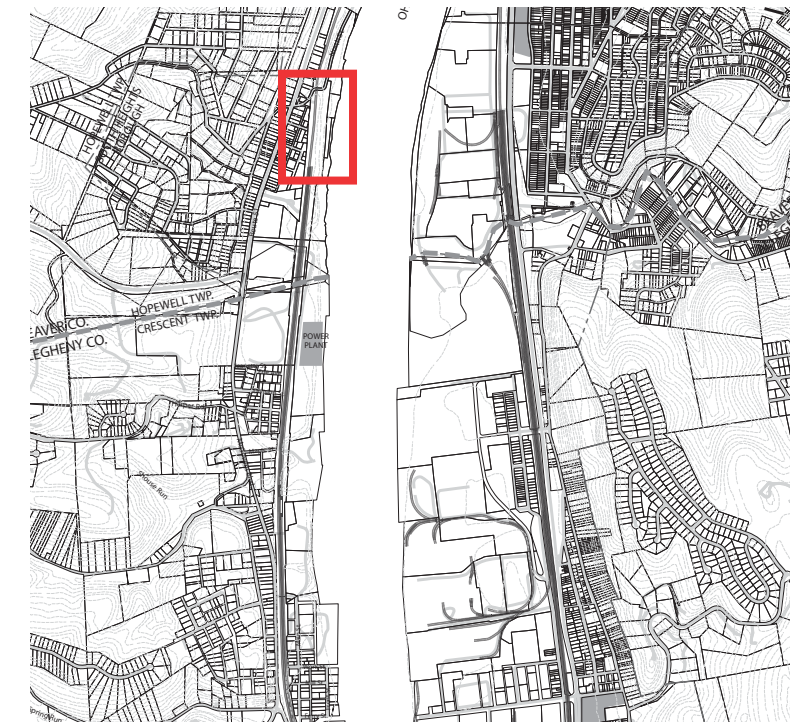
411 POWERPLANT BRIDGE OVER CSX RIGHT-OF-WAY LOOKING NORTH (EXISTING)
SCALE: 1"=10'

LEGEND

- Proposed 10' Wide Multi-Use Path Route
- - - Alternative On-Road Signed Trail Route



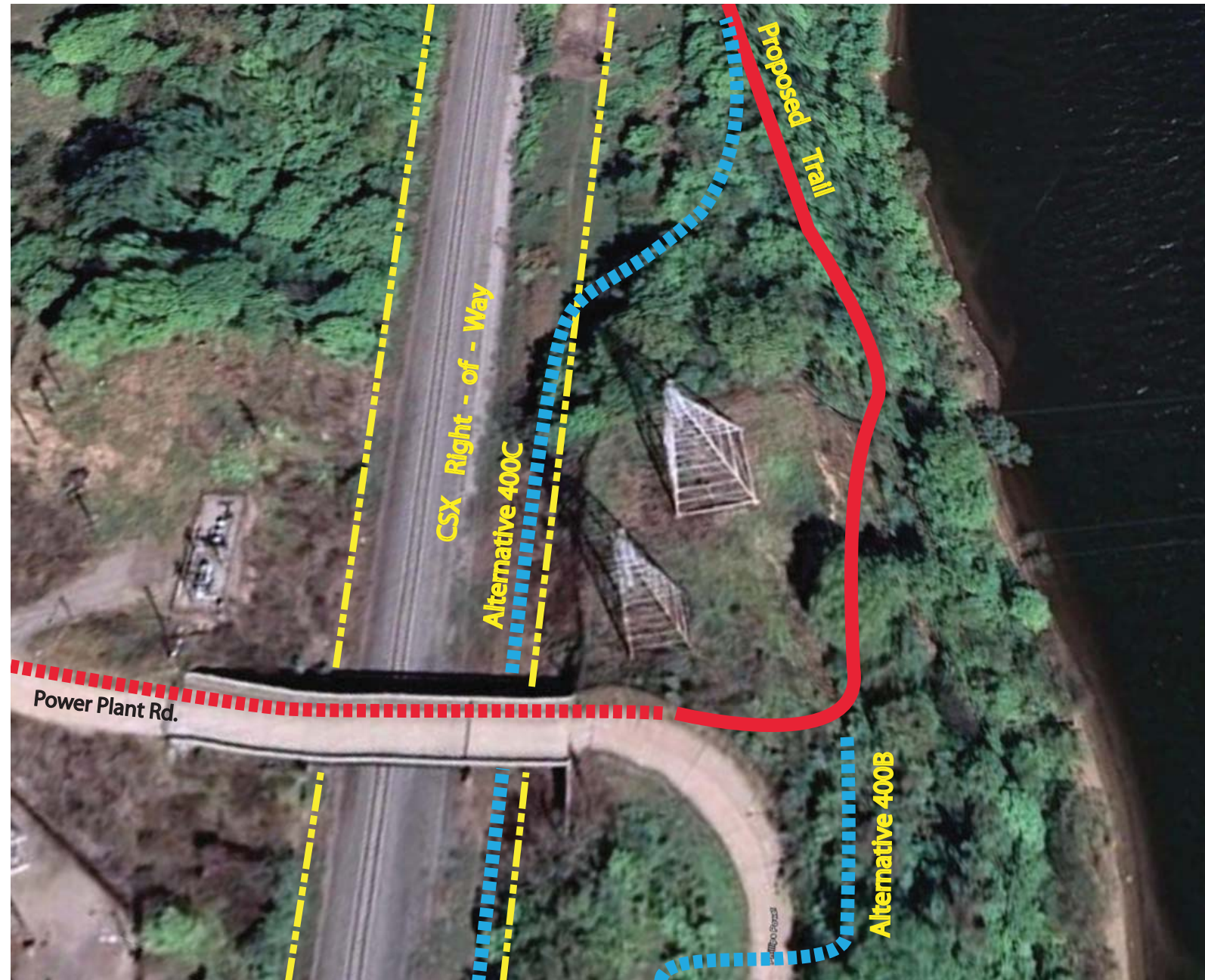
420 Proposed Trail Location
SCALE: Not to Scale



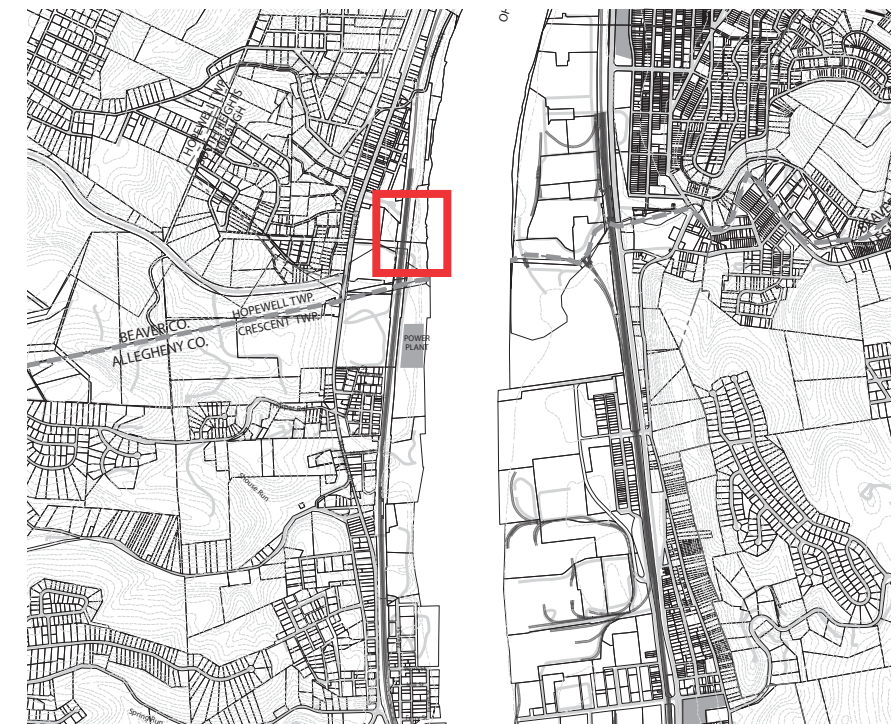
Site Photo Location

LEGEND

- Proposed 10' Wide Multi-Use Path Route
- - - Proposed On-Road Signed Trail Route
- - - Alternative 10' Wide Multi-Use Path Route



421 Proposed Trail Location
SCALE: Not to Scale



Site Photo Location